

TURF — Design & Pipeline

Summary

Working title. Summary of design session — companion to composite-gdd.md and production-pipeline.md.

Concept

Grid-based tactics roguelike set in a Nordic 90s street underworld — punks, addicts, pimps, and enforcers fighting over turf. Composite design pulling from:

- **Into the Breach** — full-information enemy telegraphing, precision puzzle feel
- **Metal Slug Tactics** — MST-scale grid (larger, variable size), numerous weaker enemies, pixel-art silhouette clarity
- **Mewgenics** — persistent named crew, loot/XP progression (no breeding/permadeath economy adopted)
- **Tactical Breach Wizards** — clean, readable turn resolution as a design ideal

- **Fights in Tight Spaces** — referenced only, not adopted (no card-based economy)

Core Design Decisions

- **Action economy:** Move + Act, either order, once each per unit (XCOM/ITB standard — not MST's move-then-act lock)
- **Telegraphing:** Full ITB-style visibility by default (exact enemy target/intent shown pre-turn); partial-hidden-intent mode possible later for difficulty
- **Win condition:** Eliminate all enemies
- **Loss condition:** Squad wipe (primary); turn-limit survival (secondary, sometimes); resource-depletion (rare, not in v1)
- **Squad:** 3 units, classic tactics triangle — Melee / Ranged (handgun or shotgun) / Support-Control. Character theming deferred to a later pass.
- **Enemies:** Mostly identical grunts + 1–2 elites as the base model, layered with weapon-profile variety (melee: blunt/knockback vs. sharp/bleed; ranged: handgun/steady vs. shotgun/burst). Scripted boss is a Phase 1 stretch goal.
- **Hazards:** Two types — full cover (blocks movement + LOS) and XCOM-style

partial/ranged cover (reduces ranged hit chance/damage, doesn't block LOS/movement)

- **Progression:** XP levels + simple weapon-swap loot (v1); roadmap toward armor, consumables, territory bonuses, and gear-driven combo/sync unlocks between units (itemized version of MST's Synchronization) as long-term goals
- **Persistence:** Units survive within a run and carry XP/loot forward. No permadeath-as-currency, no breeding system.

Tech & Production Plan

- **Prototype build:** Web-based (JS/TS, Three.js-style), consistent with existing browser-first prototyping pattern
- **Port target:** Godot 4.x, chosen primarily for controller support and a cleaner mobile/handheld export pipeline. Unity considered and set aside for now (heavier footprint, less aligned with the JS-first prototyping workflow); revisit only if a specific plugin need (e.g. advanced pathfinding) justifies it later.
- **Data architecture:** Flat, human-editable JSON (`units.json`, `weapons.json`, `enemies.json`, `encounters.json`,

`trinkets.json`) — data-driven from day one so art, balance, and level passes can proceed independently

- **Repo:** Living inside the Suds-Jack repo/hub for now, alongside other Suds-Jack projects, rather than a standalone repo

Art & Animation Pipeline

- **Art tool:** Aseprite for the eventual hand-pixel-art pass — desktop-only (Windows/Mac/Linux), no official Android app; a third-party viewer (AseVee) exists for previewing `.aseprite` files on Android but isn't an editor. Aseprite does expose a Lua scripting API + CLI, useful for automating sprite sheet export once the data pipeline is in place.
- **Sequencing:** AI-assisted placeholder sprites now (grid-locked pixel generators, not generic image models, since generic models produce anti-aliased/off-grid output that doesn't hold up as true pixel art) → hand-drawn/hand-cleaned pass in Aseprite later, once the core loop and roster are validated.
- **Animation approach:** avoid independently prompting each frame (causes

proportion/silhouette drift — the most common AI-animation failure mode). Prefer locking one base pose per archetype and either using rig/skeleton-based reposing or reference-locked generation to keep frames consistent; mirror for opposite-facing directions rather than generating all 8 angles independently; hand-align in Aseprite for the final pass.

- **Enemy sprite plan:** shared base grunt skeleton with palette/prop swaps for the 4 weapon-profile variants (melee-blunt, melee-sharp, ranged-handgun, ranged-shotgun), plus distinct silhouettes for 1–2 elite variants.

Production Milestones

1. **Milestone 1 — Phase 1 combat feel-test:** single encounter, 3 fixed player units, 2–3 enemy archetypes, full telegraphing, both cover types, eliminate-all win condition. No progression systems. Exit criteria: the fight is fun/tense repeated with nothing else attached.
2. **Milestone 2 — Phase 2 vertical slice:** 3–5 encounters in sequence, basic

XP/leveling, weapon-swap loot, variable grid/enemy count per encounter.

3. **Milestone 3 — Godot port planning:** deferred until Milestone 2 validates the loop; revisit engine comparison with real asset volume known.

Related Documents

- `composite-gdd.md` — full design document
- `production-pipeline.md` — full asset/production pipeline